

STATE POWER, SCIENCE, AND SUPERSTITION

Roman magic

▼ Bull sacrifice

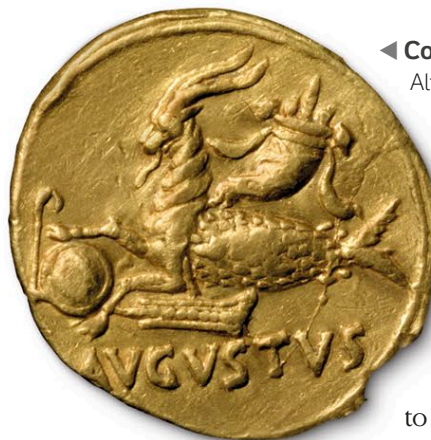
Emperor Marcus Aurelius presides over the sacrifice of a bull in gratitude for a victory in the Marcomannic Wars (166–180 CE). In this relief the *flamen* (priest) stands to the emperor's right, and the *victimarius*, who will actually kill the animal, stands to the far right bearing an ax.



As well as having their own magical beliefs, the Romans inherited from the ancient Greeks a sense that magic was a means to gain agency over the gods. Yet under Roman rule, the division between official religion and magic hardened, and there was outright persecution for practitioners of magic.

State and sorcery

Much Roman magic was inherited from the people who lived in ancient Italy before the Romans: for example, the important role of the *haruspex*—the priest who made predictions from the form and coloration of animals' livers—shows a powerful Etruscan influence on the early Roman magical



◀ Coin of Augustus

Although Emperor Augustus expelled astrologers from Rome, he still put Capricorn (the ruling sign of his own horoscope) on coins as a symbol of his renewal of the Roman state (just as Capricorn marks the return of the sun following the winter solstice).

tradition. Making public sacrifices to ensure the city's safety dated back to the 8th and 7th centuries BCE, as did augury (reading omens from weather patterns, the flight of birds, or the entrails of sacrificial animals). Under the Roman Republic from 509 BCE, both became official practices of the Roman state.

After the Roman conquest of Greece in the 2nd century BCE, the Greek belief in “binding magic” (see p.34), including using curse tablets to ensure victory in competitions or over romantic rivals, began to permeate Roman culture. Amulets also became more common (notably the *bullā*, a phallus-shaped charm worn by all Roman boys as a protection against the evil eye).

Even emperors were thought to benefit from magic. In 180 CE, when Emperor Marcus Aurelius attacked the Germanic Quadi on the Danube, his troops were saved from dying of thirst by a downpour supposedly invoked by Arnouphis, an Egyptian magician. Emperors also consulted the Sibylline Books, a collection of predictions said to have been acquired in around 520 BCE from the Sibyl, a prophetess who lived in a cave at Cumae, near Naples. Kept in the temple of Capitoline Jupiter, these books were only consulted in times of crisis, such as after the Carthaginians defeated the Roman army at Cannae in 216 BCE, when priests interpreted the books and advised that it was necessary to sacrifice two Gauls and two Greeks. The four men were buried alive beneath the Forum Boarium, the city's ancient marketplace.